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THE DELHI–MADRAS INDIAN AIRLINES FLIGHT VIA HYDERABAD was on time. It took four hours and ten minutes to land at the Meenambakkam airport. Arun Suri had arranged everything perfectly. He got the Madras office of *India Today* to send a car to pick up Anirudhya from the airport and take him to the hotel where Suri had booked him.

Anirudhya was coming back to the capital of Dravidian culture exactly a decade after he finished college in the city. Nothing much had changed, he felt, while passing Gemini Studios. Next was the Sapphire cinema complex. It appeared unaltered. The Anand restaurant, Spencer's ice cream soda joint and the Thousand Lights mosque. So many memories! All looked the same. The car entered pulled up at the hotel around 1.30 p.m. Anirudhya had heard that *India Today*'s reporters always stayed in five-star hotels. This was his first.

'Welcome to the Taj, Mr Mitra,' a woman's voice came from behind him. She was dressed in a meticulously draped brick-colour Kanjivaram silk sari. How did she know his name, Anirudhya asked, when he hadn't even checked in? 'It's not difficult, sir,' she replied, guiding him to his room on the ground floor. 'Room No. 40, a corner one. Hope you have an enjoyable stay here, sir.' She left. Soon the telephone rang. The receptionist was requesting his presence for his signature. He was impressed by *India Today*'s clout and the hotel's hospitality.

After doing the relevant paperwork, the first thing Anirudhya did was dial Amit Verma at the SIT's office. He came on the line through the operator.

'Hi! You reached?'

'Yes, I did.'

'So?'